

Session 19: The Wide and Narrow Gates

Key Takeaways

- Jesus' warnings are addressed to the generation of Israelites living during his lifetime. To best understand the importance of Jesus' warnings for us today, we must first consider what his words meant for the people he was speaking to.
- Biblical prophets used cosmic language to describe what was happening in their time and place, showing how those events were participating in a cosmic narrative.
- Jesus echoes the Hebrew Bible theme of the two paths, which stretches all the way back to the exile from the garden of Eden in Genesis 3.

Three Warnings

Just as the sermon began with three sets of three blessings and three hopeful images that described the ancient vocation of Jesus' disciples (5:3-16), now the sermon concludes with three warnings that balance the introduction. Here, Jesus will challenge his listeners to take his words seriously as a high-stakes decision is placed before them.

We must remember the historical and social location of Jesus' warnings.

"Jesus ... predicted that judgment would fall on the nation in general and on Jerusalem in particular. That is to say, he reinterprets a standard Jewish belief (the coming judgment which would fall on the nations) in terms of a coming judgment which would fall on impenitent Israel. The great prophets had done exactly the same. Jerusalem, under its present regime, had become Babylon. ... Jesus seems to have adopted the theme from John, who predicted 'wrath to come', saying that membership in physical Israel was no guarantee of a share in the age to come. Very much in the mold of Amos, or indeed of Qumran, John insisted on redrawing the boundaries of Israel; for him, only those who repented and submitted to baptism would be included. The story Jesus told about Israel's immediate future seems to have developed directly from this point. ... The warnings ... are manifestly and obviously, within their historical context, warnings about a coming national disaster, involving the destruction by Rome of the nation, the city and the Temple. The story of judgment and vindication which Jesus told is very much like the story told by the prophet Jeremiah, invoking the categories of cosmic disaster in order to invest the coming socio-political disaster with its full theological significance. The 'normal' way of reading these passages within the Christian tradition has been to see them as references to a general post mortem judgment in hell; but this betrays a fairly thorough lack of historical understanding. ... [Even] though such warnings, echoing as they did a centuries-long prophetic tradition, could in principle have been articulated at any time in Israel's history, Jesus' own warnings carried a constant reference to the present generation. ... Jesus seems to have stressed 'the signs of the times': the story he was telling was not about some general or abstract truth, of

which the present moment just happened to be one example. His message was specifically directed to that very moment in Israel's history."

Wright, N. T. (1997). [*Jesus and the Victory of God \(Christian Origins and the Question of God\)*](#). Fortress Press. 323–325.

Two Gates and Roads

A 13 Enter through the **narrow gate** .

B' a Because **wide is the gate** , and broad
b **is the road that leads to ruin** ,
c and those who enter through it are many.

A' a' 14 How **narrow is the gate** , and constricted,
b' **is the road that leads to life** ,
c' and those who find it are few.

Matthew 7:13-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Within the Hebrew Bible, there is a traditional metaphor of the two paths (the two ways) that express the two life-trajectories a person can experience, one that leads to life, and one that leads to ruin.

In biblical wisdom, the emphasis can be on the present or future fulfillment of a person's life trajectory.

Psalm 1:6 NASB

For the LORD knows **the way** of the righteous,
but **the way** of the wicked will perish.

Psalm 119:1 NASB

How blessed are those whose **way is blameless**,
who walk in the law of the LORD.

Proverbs 2:6–13 NASB

⁶ For the LORD gives wisdom;
from his mouth come knowledge and understanding. ...

⁸ Guarding **the paths** of justice,
and he preserves **the way** of his godly ones. ...

¹¹ Discretion will guard you,
understanding will watch over you,

¹² to deliver you from **the way** of evil,

from the man who speaks perverse things;
¹³ from those who leave **the paths** of uprightness
to walk in **the ways** of darkness;

Proverbs 16:25 NASB

There is a way which seems right to a man,
but its end is the **way of death**.

The imagery of the two paths is developed out a view of reality that all trajectories lead to either life and flourishing or ruin and destruction.

Psalms 16:10–11 LEB

for you will not abandon my soul to Sheol;
you will not give your faithful one to see the grave.
You will make known to me **the path of life** (אֶרֶץ חַיִּים).
Before your face is fullness of joy.
At your right hand are pleasures forever.

Psalms 139:23–24 Instructor's Translation

Search me, O God, and know my heart;
try me and know my anxious thoughts;
and see if there be any **hurtful way** in me,
and lead me in **the way of the age** (דֶּרֶךְ עוֹלָם).

Isaiah 59:7–8 NASB

Their feet run to evil,
and they are **quick** to shed innocent blood;
their thoughts are thoughts of iniquity,
devastation and destruction are **in their highways**.
They do not know **the way of peace**,
and there is **no justice in their tracks**;
they have made **their paths crooked**,
whoever **treads on them** does not know peace.

Isaiah 65:2–3 NASB

I have spread out my hands all day long to a rebellious people,
who walk in the way which is not good, following their own thoughts,
a people who continually provoke me to my face,
offering sacrifices in gardens and burning incense on bricks;

These texts are all developed out of a foundational image in the garden of Eden story, namely the mention of a “path” in and out of the garden, as well as the “gate/door” that marks the boundary.

Genesis 3:24 NASB

So he drove the man out; and at the east of the garden of Eden he stationed the cherubim and the flaming sword which turned every direction to guard **the way** (הדרך) to the tree of life.

Genesis 4:7 Instructor's Translation

If you do good,
won't there be exaltation?
And if you don't do good,
sin is a croucher at **the door** (פתח),
and its desire is for you,
but you can rule it.

To go "out through the door" means leaving Eden into the land of dust and death. To go "inside through the door" means entering Eden.

These two images—the gate-door and the path that both lead out of or into Eden—seem to lie at the fountainhead of these biblical images of the two gates and the two paths within the Hebrew Bible.

If that is so, it makes good sense that Jesus would draw on these foundational images as the lead warning.

The Door-Gate Motif in the Torah and Second Temple Literature

The door of Eden is a motif that begins with Genesis 3:22-24 and 4:7, with Eden's "gate" being described as an "entrance door" (פתח) or a "gate" (שער).

This image is developed throughout the Torah, as other Eden-like places are often marked by a door/gate entrance.

- The door of the ark (Gen. 6:14 "place the door of the ark in the side of it" and 6:17, 20 "I will establish my covenant with you and you will enter into the ark ... to preserve life"): Inside the door is rescue and life, outside the door is ruin and death.
- The door of Lot's house in Sodom (Gen. 19:6, 11): On the outside of the door is darkness and blindness, on the inside of the door is safety, refuge, and preservation of life.
- The Heaven-on-Earth stair-ramp that Jacob encounters at Bethel is called "the gate of heaven" (Gen. 28:17).
- The house on Passover: On the inside of the door with the blood is the preservation of life (Exod. 12:22-23), on the outside of the door is death.
- Tabernacle: At the boundary of the tabernacle courtyard is the "doorway" (פתח) (Exod. 26:36, 29:4), also called "the gate" (שער: Exod. 27:16, 35:17, 38:15) through which only priests and pure offerers may come. Moses stands at the "door" of the tent to intercede for Israel (Exod. 33:9-10).
- Sacrifices: In Leviticus, the altar is in front of the "door" so that all offerings are made "at the doorway of the tent of meeting" (Lev. 1:3, 5; 3:2; 4:4, 7, 18, etc.)

The imagery of a "door-gate" of death appears occasionally in the Hebrew Bible and in Second Temple literature.

Psalms 107:17-18 NASB

Fools, because of their rebellious way,
and because of their iniquities, were afflicted.
Their soul abhorred all kinds of food,
and they drew near to **the gates of death**.

Job 38:16–17 NASB

Have you entered into the springs of the sea
or walked in the recesses of the deep?
Have **the gates of death** been revealed to you,
or have you seen the gates of deep darkness?

Matthew 16:18 NASB

I also say to you that you are Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church;
and **the gates of the grave** (Greek: *hades*) will not overpower it.

3 Maccabees 5:51 NRSV

and [the Israelites] cried out in a very loud voice, imploring the Ruler over every power to manifest himself
and be merciful to them, as they stood now at **the gates of death**.

“^{4*} For he showed him many warnings together with the ways of the Law and the end of time, as also to you; and then further, also the likeness of Zion with its measurements which was to be made after the likeness of the present sanctuary. ⁵ But he also showed him, at that time, the measures of fire, the depths of the abyss, the weight of the winds, the number of the raindrops, ⁶ the suppression of wrath, the abundance of long-suffering, the truth of judgment, ^{7*} the root of wisdom, the richness of understanding, the fountain of knowledge, ⁸ the height of the air, the greatness of Paradise, the end of the periods, the beginning of the day of judgment, ⁹ the number of offerings, the worlds which have not yet come, ¹⁰ **the mouth of gehenna**, the standing place of vengeance, the place of faith, the region of hope,”

Charlesworth, James H. (1983). [*The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*](#). Yale University Press. 642.

Babylonian Talmud, Eruvin 19A:

“They acknowledge the justice of their punishment and say before him, ‘Lord of the world, you have judged well, you have condemned well, you have properly assigned Gehenna for the wicked and the Garden of Eden for the righteous.’ But is that so? And didn’t R. Simeon b. Laqish say, ‘Even **at the gate of Gehenna** the wicked don’t repent’”

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 92–93.

Conversely, the “gate to life” also appears in Second Temple Jewish literature.

Revelation 22:14–15 NASB

Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to **the tree of life**, and **may enter by the gates into the city**. Outside are the dogs and the sorcerers and the immoral persons and the murderers and the idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices lying.

Testament of Abraham 10:14-15:

“¹⁴ But I made the world, and I do not want to destroy any one of them; but I delay the death of the sinner until he should convert and live. ¹⁵ Now conduct Abraham to **the first gate of heaven**, so that there he may see the judgments and the recompenses and repent over the souls of the sinners which he destroyed.”

Charlesworth, James H. (1983). [*The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*](#). Yale University Press. 887-888.

The Two Paths in Second Temple Jewish Literature

The Qumran community developed this metaphor in multiple directions:

1QRule of the Community 3:17-21:

“¹⁷ He created man to rule ¹⁸ the world and **placed within him two spirits so that he would walk with them** until the moment of his visitation: they are the spirits ¹⁹ of truth and of deceit. From the spring of light stem the generations of truth, and from the source of darkness the generations of deceit. ²⁰ And in the hand of the Prince of Lights is dominion over all the sons of justice; they walk on **paths of light**. And in the hand of the Angel of ²¹ Darkness is total dominion over the sons of deceit; they walk on **paths of darkness**.”

García Martínez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J. C. (1997-1998). [*“The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition \(translations\)”*](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 75.

Other Second Temple Jewish literature developed the image as well.

Testament of Asher 1:3-5:

“³ God has granted two ways to the sons of men, two mind-sets, two lines of action, two models, and two goals. ⁴ Accordingly, everything is in pairs, the one over against the other. ⁵ The two ways are good and evil; concerning them are two dispositions within our breasts that choose between them”

Charlesworth, James H. (1983). [*The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*](#). Yale University Press. 816-817.

One of the earliest Christian documents after the apostolic writings is the Didache, which begins as follows.

“1. There are two ways, one of life and one of death, and there is a great difference between these two ways.
2. Now this is the way of life: first, ‘you shall love God, who made you’; second, ‘your neighbor as yourself’; and ‘whatever you do not wish to happen to you, do not do to another.’”

Holmes, Michael William (1999). [*The Apostolic Fathers: Greek Texts and English Translations, Updated ed.*](#). Baker Books. 251.

Later Rabbinic Literature also developed the image.

“^{2:9} He said to them, ‘Go and see what is **the straight path** to which someone should stick.’
- R. Eliezer says, ‘A generous spirit.’
- R. Joshua says, ‘A good friend.’
- R. Yose says, ‘A good neighbor.’
- R. Simeon says, ‘Foresight.’

- R. Eleazar says, 'Good will.'

He said to them, 'I prefer the opinion of R. Eleazar b. Arakh, because in what he says is included everything you say.'

He said to them, 'Go out and see what is **the bad road**, which someone should avoid.'

- R. Eliezer says, 'Envy.'

- R. Joshua says, 'A bad friend.'

- R. Yose says, 'A bad neighbor.'

- R. Simeon says, 'Defaulting on a loan.' ...

- R. Eleazar says, 'Bad will.'"

Charlesworth, James H. (1983). [*The Old Testament Pseudepigrapha*](#). Yale University Press. 676-677.

However, there are a number of Second Temple and later Jewish texts that see in the "two paths" imagery a recall of the gate and path into and out of the garden of Eden.

4 Ezra (= 2 Esdras) 7:11-14:

"¹¹ For I did make the world for their sakes and when **Adam** transgressed my orders what was made was judged. ¹² **The ways of this world have been made narrow**, painful and difficult; they are few and evil, full of perils and fraught with great hardships, ¹³ but **the ways of the greater world are spacious** and secure and produce the fruit of immortality. ¹⁴ If, therefore, those alive do not really enter [through] these narrow and vain things they will be unable to obtain the things stored up [for them]."

Myers, Jacob M. (2008). [*I and II Esdras: A New Translation \(The Anchor Bible, vol. 42\)*](#). Yale University Press. 206.

"R. Akiva: The words of Him who brought the world into being are not to be contested, for all of them are in accordance with truth and justice.

R. Pappus expounded (Genesis 3:22) ('and the Lord G d said:)

Behold, **the human** has become like one of us' — as one of the ministering angels.

R. Akiva: 'Enough Pappus!'

Pappus: 'And how do you understand it?'

R. Akiva: The Holy One Blessed be **He gave him two paths**: one of **life** and one of **death**, and he chose **the path of death**."

Mekhilta de Rabbi Yishmael on Exodus 14:29.

Babylonian Talmud Berakhot 28B:

"before me are **two paths**, one to **the Garden of Eden** and the other to **Gehenna**, and I do not know by which path I shall be brought,"

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 189.

The Narrow / Persecuted Way

The phrase in [Matthew 7:14](#), "narrow is the way" in Greek is τεθλιμμένη ἡ ὁδὸς / *tethlimmene he-hodos*. The participle comes from the root θλίβω / *thlibo*, which literally means "to press hard against" or "to constrict"

and metaphorically means “to cause trouble for, to oppress.”

The noun derived from this verb is θλίψις / *thlipsis* “oppression, tribulation, persecution,” which Matthew often uses to describe hostile resistance to Jesus and his disciples.

Matthew 13:20–21 NASB*

The one on whom seed was sown on the rocky places, this is the man who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy; yet he has no firm root in himself, but is only temporary, and when ***thlipsis*** or persecution arises because of the word, immediately he falls away.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Matthew 24:9 NASB*

Then they will deliver you to ***thlipsis***, and will kill you, and you will be hated by all nations because of my name.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Matthew 24:21 NASB*

For then there will be a great ***thlipsis***, such as has not occurred since the beginning of the world until now, nor ever will.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jesus is almost certainly activating both meanings of this word in describing the “way” of following his teachings:

1. Within his parable, “the way” is narrow and constricted. That is, it requires intentionality and effort to stay on the path, in contrast to the wide and broad path.
2. Within Jesus’ social context, his “way” will lead to “oppression.” That is, hostility from Israel’s leaders and from community members who misunderstand who Jesus is and what he’s all about.

“Opposite the broad way is the “difficult way” (ὁδὸς τεθλιμμένη). That does not mean, as is usually maintained, simply the narrow, small way. It is true that τεθλιμμένος can mean “made narrow,” but in the sense that the passage becomes crowded in, for example, a city or a house when there are too many people. That is not what it means here, however, because only a few people are on the way that leads to life. Thus it is better to understand τεθλιμμένος as a reference to the tribulations (θλίψεις) that Matthew mentions in several places for the time before the eschaton (24:9, 21, 29; cf. 13:21). Already 5:10–12, 44 speak of the persecution the community experiences. Thus the way to life is full of hardships.”

Luz, Ulrich (2007). [*Matthew 1–7: A Commentary \(Hermeneia\)*](#). Augsburg Fortress Publishing. 372.

The Many and the Few

Davies and Allison have an important discussion about the “many” and “few” in Matthew 7:14.

“Is [the line ‘few are those who find it’] rhetorical, an invitation to make a decision, or ... is it a calculation, a statement that the masses of humanity will be damned? In favor of the second view, one could cite Matthew 22:14 (‘Many are called but few are chosen’); but against it one could refer to Matthew 8:11 (‘Many

shall come from east and west') and [20:28](#) ('the son of Man did not come to be served but to serve and give his life as a ransom for many'). If the issue cannot be resolved with certainty, this is so for two reasons. (1) First, Matthew has not made an attempt to be systematic and perfectly consistent in preserving these sayings. This is why one verse can speak of the salvation of a few, another of Jesus ransoming many. (2) Secondly, one does well to keep in mind the Semitic habit of making hyperbolic declarations as a means of exhortation. Consider Mishna Qiddushin 1:10: 'If a man performs a single commandment, it shall be well with him and he shall have length of days and shall inherit the land; but if he neglects a single commandment it shall be ill with him and he shall not have length of days and shall not inherit the land'. It would be perverse to take these words literally. They are exhortation. A person should act as if the fulfilment of one commandment meant everything. Similarly, the true meaning of [Mt. 7:13-14](#) could be: act as if only a very few will enter through the gates of paradise. On this reading, one would do wrong to find in this passage an objective numerical estimate. (Note that in [Lk. 13:23-24](#) Jesus does not directly answer the question, Will those who are saved be few? He instead throws the question back at his listeners by commanding them to strive to enter the narrow door.)"

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 700-701.

There are sayings of Jesus where it seems he held an optimistic view that the majority of humanity will be enfolded within the saving purpose of God. (These sayings about "the many" are all hyperlinked to a key text in the suffering servant poems of Isaiah.)

Matthew 8:10-11 NASB

Now when Jesus heard this, he marveled and said to those who were following, "Truly I say to you, I have not found such great faith with anyone in Israel. I say to you that **many will come from east and west, and recline at the table with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven;**"

Matthew 20:28 NASB

just as the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and **to give his life a ransom for many.**

John 12:31-32 NASB

Now judgment is upon this world; now the ruler of this world will be cast out.
And I, if I am lifted up from the earth, will draw **all people** to myself.

Isaiah 53:11 NASB

As a result of the anguish of his soul,
he will see it and be satisfied;
by his knowledge **the Righteous One,**
my Servant, will declare righteous the many,
as he will bear their iniquities.

There are other sayings of Jesus where it seems that Jesus held a pessimistic view of the same point.

Matthew 22:14 NASB

For **many** are called, but few are chosen.

One critical note about the above topic is that it would be easy at this point to think that Jesus' words about the two gates and two roads are about the individual's life-journey to a destiny of eternal life with God after death, or of ruin and destruction after death.

This would be to misunderstand the historical setting of Jesus' warnings and of their reference. Jesus had a clear understanding of what his warnings of judgment were about: a coming disaster for the nation of Israel that would be another repetition of the Scriptural covenant cycle of unfaithfulness leading to defeat at the hands of oppressive empires. Elsewhere in Matthew, Jesus uses the same language we find in [Matthew 5-7](#) to describe the downfall of Jerusalem at the hands of the Romans.

Matthew 24:1-5 NASB

¹ Jesus came out from the temple and was going away when his disciples came up to point out **the temple buildings to him**. ² And he said to them, "Do you not see all these things? Truly I say to you, not one stone here will be left upon another, which will not be torn down." ³ As he was sitting on the Mount of Olives, the disciples came to him privately, saying, "Tell us, when will these things happen, and what will be the sign of your coming, and of the end of the age?" ⁴ And Jesus answered and said to them, "See to it that no one misleads you. ⁵ **For many will come in my name**, saying, 'I am the Christ,' **and will mislead many.**"

See [Matthew 7:15-23](#)

Matthew 24:9 NASB

Then they will deliver you to tribulation, and will kill you, and **you will be hated by all nations because of my name**.

See [Matthew 5:10-12](#)

Matthew 24:10-13 NASB

At that time **many will fall away** and will betray one another and hate one another. **Many** false prophets will arise and will **mislead many**. Because lawlessness is increased, the love of **many** will grow cold. But the one who endures to the end, he will be saved.

See [Matthew 7:13-14](#)

Matthew 24:21-22 NASB

For then there will be **a great trial**, such as has not occurred since the beginning of the world until now, nor ever will. Unless those days had been cut short, no life would have been saved; but for the sake of the elect those days will be cut short.

See [Matthew 7:13-14](#)

Matthew 24:24 NASB

For false Christs and false prophets will arise and will show great signs and wonders, so as to mislead, if possible, even the elect.

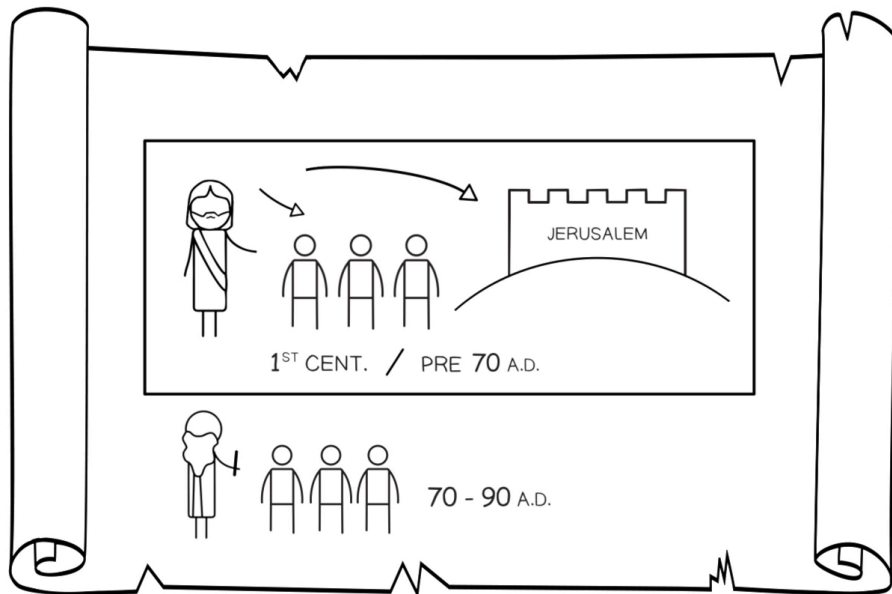
See [Matthew 7:15-23](#)

Matthew 24:37-39 NASB

For the coming of the Son of Man will be just like the days of Noah. For as in those days before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day that Noah entered the ark, and they did not understand until the flood came and took them all away; so will the coming of the Son of Man be.

See [Matthew 7:24-27](#)

Narrative Perspective of Matthew



Narrative Perspective of Matthew. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Reflection Question

Who is Jesus addressing in his warnings in [Matthew 7:13-14](#)? How might this shape our understanding of his words and what they mean for us today?